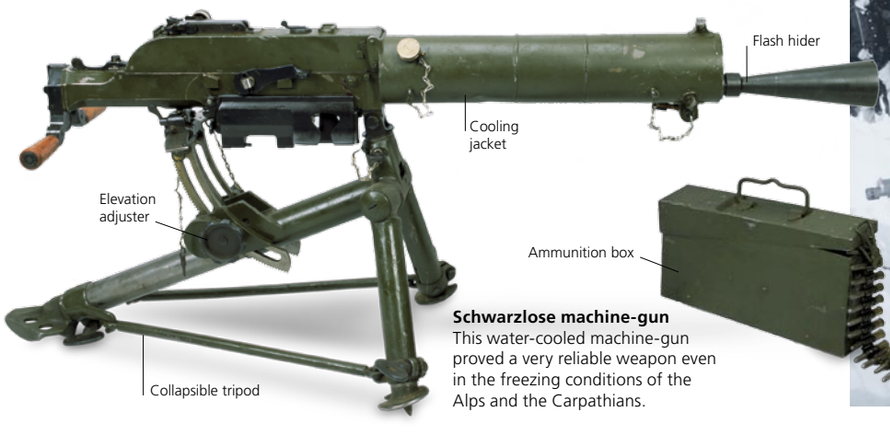
THE AUSTRO-HUNGARIAN ARMY

The Austro-Hungarian army reflected the complexity of a multinational empire in which Austrian Germans and Hungarians dominated assorted other peoples – chiefly Czechs, Slovaks, Croats, Slovenes, Bosnians, Ruthenes, and Poles. The majority of officers were German speakers, while nearly half the conscripts were Slavs, many of whom spoke no German. The army, however, initially fought well and the infantry was supplied with good quality weapons for trench warfare, even if quantities were insufficient. But cracks in loyalty to the empire soon began to appear. The shock of the Russian Brusilov offensive in summer 1916 led to mass desertions by Czechs and Ruthenes. The exhausted army later came increasingly under the control of its German allies, a fact resented by many of the troops. By September 1918, with defeat inevitable, the army was disintegrating into its separate national components. Probably around a million Austro-Hungarian soldiers died in the war.

Mountain troops
The Austrians had specialist Alpine troops, whose skills were called on both in northeast Italy and in the Carpathian mountains against the Russians.





Schwarzlose machine-gun
This water-cooled machine-gun proved a very reliable weapon even in the freezing conditions of the Alps and the Carpathians.

TURKISH TROOPS



When it entered World War I as an ally of Germany in November 1914, the multinational Ottoman Empire was in the middle of a political upheaval that would eventually create the nation-state of Turkey. Its conscript army was largely recruited from the Turkish Anatolian peasantry. There were Kurdish and Arab units, but these could not be relied on, and Jews and Christians were only used in support roles. The Turkish Army had performed poorly in recent wars in the Balkans and against Italy. When Allied forces carried out the Gallipoli landings in April 1915, they were astonished by the resilience and motivation of the Turkish soldiers. A German observer attributed the troops' performance to "stubborn devotion and unshakeable loyalty to their Sultan and Caliph". For whatever reason, "Mehmedchik" – the equivalent of the British "Tommy" – was ready to die in desperate counterattacks to repulse the landings. Courage was no remedy for economic and administrative failings, however. As the war dragged on, Turkish troops ran short of food, as did the population at home. Medical services were minimal and disease took its toll. German troops, fighting alongside the Turks, occasioned great resentment because of their superior food supplies and equipment. By summer 1918, defeated in Iraq and Palestine, the Turkish army was in full disintegration. Troops deserted en masse, either returning to work their abandoned fields or resorting to banditry. Over half a million Turkish soldiers died in combat, with perhaps half as many again dying of disease.



FRAGMENTATION GRENADE

Turkish weapons and unifom
The Turks were issued with Mauser rifles – some new, some older models that the Germans no longer used. The style of their khaki uniform also showed the influence of their German advisers.



9.5MM MAUSER CARBINE (1887)

BAYONET